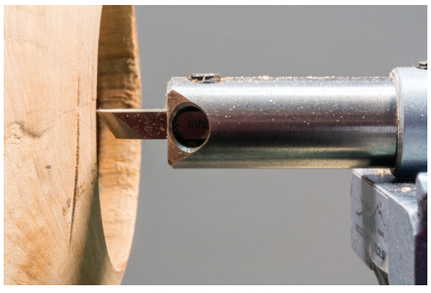
Cutters

In the beginning, the tools of choice were a machinist's tool bit mounted either forward or canted to the side and a scraper bit that could be mounted. Many fine hollow forms have been and can still be created with these tools alone. Today, there are so many other choices that you'd be foolish not to give them a try. The many carbide cutters available can be mounted to the hollowing bar, as can the shrouded versions. Because these cut much more than the machinist's tool bit, you get curls and curls coming off rather than small chips of wood. Suffice to say, you'll have a world of cutting tools to bring to bear with the proper adapters for your hollowing rig. There'll be much more on cutters in a future issue. For now, whether you use a carbide cutter, shrouded or not, or a machinist's tool bit, adjust the cutter height to be on dead centre or slightly above centre for your inside cutting. I find that keeping the hollowing rig level with my cutter adjusted slightly above centre allows for the best operation for me. There are other opinions out there so feel free to weigh those as you hone in on your own style.



I set my cutter working edge height to be ever so slightly above the centreline of the work

There are an assortment of cutters available. These are my workhorses

Cutting and cleaning

Depending on your design of turning and type of cutter, you'll have to clean the debris at varying intervals. Hollowing through a smaller hole will prevent the cuttings from exiting the turning easily. As they build up inside, they will prevent a good cutting operation from happening. Stop regularly and clean out the debris for best cutting. An air hose inserted into the opening will usually blow out the chips. Be careful of your eyes and other people around you since the debris will be flying out and can easily be a hazard even if you're using PPE. Your style of hollowing will probably vary depending on whether you are a centre steady user or not. Starting at the centre and working out towards your desired wall thickness in stages will work nicely. Working an inch deeper at a time will leave sufficient stock to support the cut while you work. After you've achieved your desired wall thickness, work on the next inch down fairing the next wall thickness cut to the last. Using your same technique as hollowing the inside of a bowl will work nicely for you.

The debris needs to be cleaned periodically to allow for effective cutting. An air hose works well

To centre steady or not

Among the hollow form turners, there is a differing opinion on whether to use a centre steady. Those that do, typically create their outside shape to its conclusion prior to hollowing. Of course, they may need to leave some meat at the bottom for workholding strength but their planned use of a centre steady allows them to create and refine their form before they begin their hollowing. Those in the other camp who don't use a centre steady do their hollowing as they create their shape. By working step by step in the depth, they always have sufficient support to do their hollowing as they progress. Much like thinning the walls of a bowl in stages, this method prevents chatter and unsupported areas by working in stages arriving at the final form at the same time hollowing is completed. Either way will work. Both camps have plenty of their own good reasons for their choice. Personally, since I own several sized centre steadies, I usually employ them since they are already sitting beside the lathes. There are several styles of centre steadies available. There are some that fully encompass the turning and there are some whose framework doesn't completely surround the work. The rollers can be positioned properly but the mechanics allow for adding and removing the steady without dismounting things. This has an advantage but does take a bit of extra fiddling around to get things adjusted properly.

Centre steadies are available in several designs and in sizes appropriate for your work and lathe

One of the newer centre steady designs whose frame doesn't surround the work

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